
AXOLOTL

Ambystoma mexicanum



Intermediate

Complete Care Package

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BeastlyFacts

Practical care guides for curious animal lovers

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How to Use This Package

This package is a practical owner manual, not a textbook. Read the Quick Profile and Care Guide once to understand the setup. Then use the checklists, water targets, and symptom reference as working tools.

Axolotl care is intermediate mainly because of cold-water discipline, filtration, and substrate safety - not because the animal is hard to feed. Temperature mistakes kill faster than almost any other error.

Print these first

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1. Quick Profile

The axolotl (*Ambystoma mexicanum*) is a neotenic salamander endemic to the lake complex of Xochimilco near Mexico City. It retains larval features (external gills, fully aquatic lifestyle) for its entire life and never undergoes metamorphosis. Adults reach 9-12 inches. Captive lifespan is typically 10-15 years. IUCN status: Critically Endangered, with fewer than 1,000 estimated remaining in the wild.

Native Range	Xochimilco lake complex, Mexico City
Natural Habitat	Freshwater lakes and canals
Adult Size	9-12 inches (23-30 cm)
Wild Diet	Worms, mollusks, insects, small fish, invertebrates
Captive Diet	Nightcrawlers + carnivore pellets
Typical Lifespan	10-15 years
Difficulty	Intermediate
Conservation	Critically Endangered (IUCN)

Fun Facts

- Can regenerate entire limbs, heart, spinal cord, and parts of the brain with zero scarring.
 - Never 'grows up' in the usual salamander sense - stays fully aquatic with feathery gills for life.
 - Millions exist in captivity for biomedical research and as pets while the wild population collapses.
 - No eyelids - they prefer dim light and avoid direct sunlight.
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Cost Overview

Standard morphs cost about \$30-100; rarer colors cost more. Basic setup \$200-500; with a chiller \$450-900. Ongoing monthly costs typically \$15-45 for food, water conditioner, filter media, and chiller electricity. A chiller is often the largest single expense in warm climates.

2. Full Care Guide

Housing & Tank

Minimum 20-gallon long aquarium for one adult; 40-gallon breeder preferred (especially for two). Floor space matters more than height. Use a secure lid. The tank must be fully cycled before the animal is added - axolotls do not tolerate uncycled water.

Can house pairs in large tanks, but monitor for nipping - they can bite off gills (which regrow). **Never** house with fish. Dim lighting preferred; avoid direct sunlight.



Example axolotl tank setup

Water Temperature & Quality

Temperature is the single most critical parameter: 60-68°F ideal. Above 72°F causes severe stress, immune failure, and fungal risk. Above 75°F can be fatal within days. No heater. Use a chiller or fan-based cooling in warm climates. Check gills daily - curled or forward-facing gill tips are an early heat-stress warning.

Ammonia and nitrite must read 0. Nitrate under 10 ppm preferred. pH about 7.4-7.8. Test weekly. Weekly 20-25% water changes with dechlorinated water matched for temperature. High ammonia causes gill regression and wasting.

Filtration & Flow

Gentle, low-flow filtration only. Sponge filter or canister with output baffled or diffused through a spray bar. Strong currents stress delicate gills. Create a still-water refuge on one end if flow is present on the other.

Substrate & Furnishings

Bare-bottom or fine sand under 1 mm grain size only. **Never** use gravel or small rocks - impaction is a leading cause of preventable death. Large river stones are acceptable only if each is at least 2x the width of the adult's head.

Provide at least 2-3 hides per adult: sideways terracotta pots (drainage hole sealed with aquarium-safe silicone), wide-diameter PVC pipe (≥ 4 inches, edges fully sanded), or smooth ceramic/resin caves. Live or silk plants for cover: Java fern, Anubias (rhizome not buried), Marimo moss balls larger than the head, Hornwort.

Diet & Feeding

Carnivorous. Primary food: nightcrawlers / earthworms from a pesticide-free source, cut to size for juveniles. Supplemental: high-quality carnivore pellets (Hikari Carnivore or Repashy Grub Pie gel) offered with tongs; remove uneaten within 20 minutes. Occasional variety: thawed bloodworms, brine shrimp, daphnia, silkworm larvae.

Juveniles: daily. Adults: every other day to 3 times per week. Target-feed with tongs rather than broadcast feeding (broadcast wastes food and fouls water). Scatter or tong-feed worms so the animal must locate them - this is both nutrition and enrichment.

Handling

Handle only when unavoidable (tank maintenance, health checks). Guide the axolotl into a submerged container while still underwater. Keep it in water at all times. **Never** use a net - fine gill filaments and toes snag in mesh and tear. Do not lift by hand into air; the skeleton is largely cartilage and air exposure plus pressure cause real injury and stress.

For new arrivals, drip-acclimate by slowly matching bag/container water to tank chemistry and temperature rather than dumping or handling.

Enrichment

Enrichment is about choice, not toys: multiple secure resting sites, opportunities to hunt rather than receive food, gentle flow variation, and occasional spatial novelty. Highest-impact, lowest-risk interventions are multiple smooth hides, live or silk plant cover, and varied feeding presentation.

Structural: 2-4 hides of varying shapes and heights. Foraging: tong or scatter feed in varied locations; short supervised sand-saucer hunts with very fine sand if the rest of the tank is bare-bottom. Sensory: monthly mild rearrangement of non-hide decor; dim lighting or floating plants for dappled shade. All edges must be sanded smooth - if an item scratches your hand, it will injure the axolotl.

Common Mistakes to Avoid

- **Never** let water stay above 72°F (fatal risk above 75°F).
- **Never** use gravel or coarse sand - impaction kills.
- **Never** use a net for routine handling.
- **Never** add an axolotl to an uncycled tank.
- **Never** use a heater.
- **Never** house with fish.
- **Never** broadcast-feed and leave excess food to foul the water.

3. Health & Common Issues

Most axolotl emergencies are temperature or water-quality driven. Find an aquatic or exotic-amphibian vet in advance - general small-animal clinics often are not equipped. Check gills daily as an early warning system.

Red Flags - Act Early

- Water above 72°F or curled/forward-facing gills (heat stress).
 - White or grey cotton-like growth on gills or body (fungus).
 - Bloating, floating, no waste, appetite loss (possible impaction).
 - Red inflamed patches on skin or gills (ammonia/nitrite burn).
 - Appetite loss lasting 5+ days, red streaking, or open wounds.
 - Fungal growth not improved within 48 hours of correcting water quality.
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Fungal Infection

White or grey cotton-like growth on gills or body, triggered by warm water, poor water quality, stress, or injury.

What to do

- Correct temperature and water quality first; retest parameters
- Mild cases may respond to cool water changes under vet guidance
- Persistent or spreading growth needs veterinary antifungal care

What not to do

- Never dose random aquarium meds without guidance
 - Never wait if growth is spreading across gills
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Impaction

From ingesting gravel or substrate too large to pass. Signs: bloating, floating instead of resting on the bottom, appetite loss, absence of waste.

Prevention

- Bare-bottom or fine sand under 1 mm only
- No gravel, coarse sand, or small loose stones

What to do

- Contact an aquatic/exotic vet; severe cases may need intervention

What not to do

- Never use gravel substrate with axolotls

Heat Stress & Water Quality Burns

Heat stress suppresses the immune system and can be fatal. Early signs: curled or forward-facing gill tips, appetite loss, floating, pale patches. Ammonia and nitrite burns appear as red, inflamed patches from an uncycled or poorly maintained tank.

What to do

- Cool water immediately if at or above 72°F (sealed ice bottles, chiller, fan)
- Test ammonia/nitrite/nitrate; large water change if needed
- Test weekly going forward

What not to do

- Never dump ice directly into the tank
- Never ignore forward-curved gills

4. Quick Reference & Checklist

Essential Setup Checklist

- 20-gallon long minimum (40-gal preferred) fully cycled tank with lid
- Bare-bottom or fine sand <1 mm only
- Low-flow sponge or baffled canister filter
- Chiller or reliable cooling method for 60-68°F
- Accurate thermometer + liquid test kit (ammonia, nitrite, nitrate, pH)
- 2-4 smooth hides (terracotta, sanded PVC, ceramic caves)
- Live or silk plants (Java fern, Anubias, Marimo)
- Dechlorinator, tongs for feeding, nightcrawler source
- Submerged transfer container (no nets)

Water Quality & Temperature Targets

Parameter	Target	Notes
Temperature	60-68°F	Above 72°F is dangerous; >75°F can kill
Ammonia	0 ppm	Test weekly; toxic at any level
Nitrite	0 ppm	Test weekly
Nitrate	<10 ppm	Water changes control this
pH	7.4-7.8	Stable is more important than exact
Flow	Low / gentle	Baffle strong outputs

Emergency & Quick Targets - Axolotl

Print this page and keep it near the enclosure. When something looks wrong, start here.

Quick Targets

Parameter	Target
Temperature	60-68°F ideal
Danger zone	Above 72°F - act now
Fatal risk	Above 75°F for prolonged time
Ammonia / Nitrite	0 ppm
Nitrate	Under 10 ppm preferred
pH	About 7.4-7.8

Red Flags - Act Early

- Curled or forward-facing gills (heat stress)
- White/grey cotton growth on gills or body
- Floating, bloating, no waste (possible impaction)
- Red inflamed gills/skin (ammonia/nitrite burn)
- Appetite loss 5+ days
- Red streaking or open wounds

Do This Now

- Cool water immediately if $\geq 72^{\circ}\text{F}$ (bottles of frozen water, chiller, fan)
- Test ammonia/nitrite/nitrate; large water change if needed
- Contact aquatic/exotic amphibian vet - no nets during moves

5. Owner Tools & Decision Guides

Budget & Shopping List

Basic setup \$200-500; with chiller \$450-900. Monthly \$15-45. The chiller is the item that most often determines whether axolotl keeping is realistic in a warm climate.

Shopping checklist

- 20-gal long or 40-gal breeder tank + lid
- Sponge filter or low-flow canister + media
- Chiller (or fan cooling plan) + thermometer
- Liquid test kit (ammonia, nitrite, nitrate, pH)
- Fine sand <1 mm or plan for bare-bottom
- 2-4 smooth hides + plants
- Dechlorinator, tongs, nightcrawler supply
- Submerged transfer container
- Carnivore pellets as backup food

First 30 Days Checklist

- Fully cycle the tank and confirm 0 ammonia / 0 nitrite before the animal arrives
 - Stabilize temperature at 60-68°F with cooling in place
 - Drip-acclimate the new axolotl; avoid nets and air exposure
 - Establish tong-feeding with nightcrawlers and watch for normal waste
 - Test water 2-3 times in the first two weeks, then weekly
 - Locate an aquatic/exotic amphibian vet before you need one
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Symptom Quick Reference

Sign	Possible Cause	Action
Curled / forward gills	Heat stress	Cool water immediately
White cotton on gills	Fungus	Fix water/temp; vet if persists
Floating / no waste	Possible impaction	See aquatic vet
Red inflamed gills/skin	Ammonia/nitrite burn	Test water; large change
Appetite loss 5+ days	Multiple causes	Check temp + water; vet

Daily & Weekly Routine

Print this page and keep it near the enclosure. Consistency matters more than perfection.

Daily

- Check temperature (60-68°F) - act immediately if approaching 72°F
 - Visual check of gills (curl/forward angle is an early heat-stress warning)
 - Feed on schedule with tongs; remove uneaten food within 20 minutes
 - Spot-check for floating, bloating, or cotton-like growth
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Weekly

- Test ammonia, nitrite, nitrate, and pH
 - 20-25% water change with temperature-matched dechlorinated water
 - Spot-clean waste from substrate/bottom
 - Confirm filter flow is still gentle and baffled
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Every 1-3 Months

- Staggered filter media replacement so the cycle never fully crashes
- Mild rearrangement of non-hide decor if desired
- Review chiller/cooling performance before warm seasons

Last changed / logged dates (write in):

Last full water test: _____ Filter media: _____

Last vet visit: _____ Notes: _____

Owner Log - Axolotl

Track weight and basic daily notes. Weight change is often the earliest warning sign. Print extra copies as needed.

Weight & Daily Log

Date	Temp °F	Ammonia	Ate?	Notes

Heat Emergency Protocol

- If water hits 72°F+: float sealed bottles of ice/frozen water; increase surface agitation carefully; run chiller/fan.
- Do not dump ice directly into the tank. Avoid sudden multi-degree shocks if possible, but cooling heat stress comes first.
- Watch gills - forward curl is an early warning. Persistent heat requires a reliable chiller plan, not occasional ice bottles.
- Find an aquatic/exotic amphibian vet before you need one.

Enrichment Checklist - Axolotl

Enrichment is not optional decoration. Use this as a setup and monthly review checklist.

Setup & Ongoing Checklist

- 2-4 smooth hides of different shapes/heights
- Live or silk plant cover (Java fern, Anubias, Marimo)
- Gentle flow one side + still-water refuge the other
- Tong or scatter feed so animal must search
- Rotate feeding locations every few days
- Mild monthly rearrange of non-hide decor
- New safe item 5-7 days, then rotate out
- 2-3 stable hides that never move

Monthly review notes (write in):

Date: _____ What changed: _____

Date: _____ What changed: _____

Date: _____ What changed: _____

Rule: stability for core hides/heat/water systems; novelty only in non-critical items.

Glossary

Cycling - Establishing beneficial bacteria that convert ammonia to nitrite to nitrate before adding the animal.

Impaction - Blockage of the digestive tract, often from swallowed substrate.

Neoteny - Retention of larval features (gills, aquatic lifestyle) into adulthood.

Nightcrawler - Large earthworm; primary recommended food for adult axolotls.

Sponge filter - Air-driven or pump-driven filter that provides gentle biological filtration.

UVI - Not applicable - axolotls do not use UVB basking systems.

This care package was compiled from BeastlyFacts research and practical husbandry standards.

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Disclaimer: This package is for educational purposes and is not a substitute for veterinary care. Husbandry standards evolve; always verify critical health decisions with a qualified exotic/aquatic veterinarian.

No external links are included in this document.
